

COMMAND FAILURE

■ By Satarupa Bhattacharjya

They both are Marxists and their common passion is the Tatas. One is standing his party's ideology on its head to get the Tatas to invest in his state. The other, wearing his party's ideology on his sleeves, is ordering his state's public properties to be razed, mistaking them for Tatas'. Between the two men, sits another Marxist quite unable to fathom the goings-on. These days, the CPI(M) is not just a story of two chief ministers who ignore their party boss, it is a story of a party at crossroads.

Things are happening in the CPI(M), the likes of which have seldom happened before. In Singur, a party zonal secretary is being investigated by CBI for his alleged role in the murder of a woman on December 18 last year. She had reportedly demonstrated against the party's desire to acquire agricultural land from her for the Tatas' small car factory in Singur. The whistle blower in this case was another CPI(M) member who broke out of the ranks.

Last month, a senior functionary in the *Deshabhimani*, the CPI(M) mouthpiece in Kerala, was caught accepting a bribe of Rs 1 crore from a businessman with a promise to get him off the hook in a financial scam. His suspension the next day for "indulging in acts that brought disrepute to the party" did nothing to enhance the party's image since a bigger scam was unearthed the following day. The same *Deshabhimani*, it appeared, had taken Rs 2 crore from the head of a lottery mafia (who incidentally was on the run from the police). In an effort to spare itself the blushes, the newspaper claimed that the money was nothing more than a bond it had raised. Within hours, the party realised its folly since it had no licence to issue bonds, so it discovered a new figleaf—the money, it said, was an advance for future advertisements from the lottery group. When the heat showed no signs of abating, there followed yet another attempt to wriggle



Instead of trying to expand the CPI(M)'s base in the Hind

out of the controversy. The CPI(M) state secretariat said it would return the money to the donor, only to invite taunts from the Opposition which wanted to know to whom the money would be returned since the one who had given it was on the run.

The CPI(M) has never seen such internal schism ever since the united CPI was split in 1964 or even when the Naxalites formed their own M-L faction three years later. Nor has it faced the kind of charges related to the growing corruption in the organisation, which in all fairness, has been relatively cleaner than most other political outfits. In West Bengal, the divide

between Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya and his predecessor Jyoti Basu appears unbridgeable. The aggression in Bhattacharya's industry-not-agriculture strategy has rendered the Left Front unity vulnerable just not in the state but also at the Centre. Front partners in West Bengal—CPI, RSP and Forward Bloc—often flock to Bhattacharya's mentor Basu with complaints. Basu himself is apprehensive that the Front may collapse if the chief minister does not engage with other Left parties. The Marxist patriarch, who turned 94 on July 8, is understood to have expressed anger over the handling of Nandigram and Singur.